



ST. PETERSBURG RUSSIA

Blinis and Caviar on the Baltic

Russia's hauntingly beautiful former imperial capital has been justly described as the Venice of the North. Since Czarist times, its cuisine has combined the simplicity of peasant cooking with the epicurean delights of this vast nation's rivers. Blinis with caviar are cherished by every Russian as their culinary birthright, whether eaten in a humble café or a fancy restaurant.



Founded by Czar Peter the Great to be a “window on the West” that exposed backward Holy Russia to the European Enlightenment, St. Petersburg is said to have been “built on bones” by forced labor, on a desolate swamp where the Neva River flows into the Baltic Sea. It supplanted Moscow as Russia's capital and remained so until Lenin returned the seat of power to the Kremlin. As the second city of the Soviet Union – renamed Leningrad – it withstood the epic 900 Days of Nazi siege, when 670,000 citizens perished from starvation, cold, or shelling.

Although the last czar, Nicholas II, once remarked that “St. Petersburg is Russian – but it is not Russia,” the city is associated with a host of renowned figures. Here, Tchaikovsky, Stravinsky, and Shostakovich composed; Pushkin, Gogol, and Dostoevsky wrote; Rasputin, Lenin, and Trotsky made political history; and Catherine the Great defined decadent living. The city's historical associations abound, from unbridled autocrats to suicidal poets and ruthless revolutionaries.

The city's layout was determined by Peter the Great, who regulated the size of dwellings for each social class and plotted the great avenues that converge on the golden-spined Admiralty. Nevsky Prospekt, the

city's main street, has examples of every style of architecture, from Baroque and Neo-Classical to Art Nouveau and Constructivism. The facades of this harmonious ensemble are painted in cool grays and blues or warm tawny hues, producing luminous reflections in the dark waters of the Neva River, its tributaries, and the numerous canals.

Ever since pagan times – before Russians adopted Christianity – the winter festival of Maslenitsa has been celebrated by gorging on blinis oozing melted butter, symbolizing the sun and hopes of fertile crops for the year ahead. The pancakes are traditionally prepared from buckwheat or wheat flour, mixed with butter, eggs, milk, and yeast; they can be topped with anything, but the classic accompaniment is caviar.

Red caviar (*krasnaya ikra*) is the plump orange eggs of salmon roe; it is far cheaper than black caviar (*chornaya ikra*), harvested from four varieties of Caspian sturgeon. The most treasured is the pea-sized, black-to-silvery-grey Beluga, followed by the smaller, golden Sterlet, the brownish Osetra, and lastly the gray Sevruga. Canapé-sized blinis are the perfect foil to their oily saltiness, garnished with lemon slices, a dollop of sour cream, and a sprig of dill. Each one is a delicious testament to the decadence of the czars.

A Day in St. Petersburg

The Neva River defines the city; its majestic bridges link the downtown (on the mainland) to Petrograd Side and Vasilevsky Island. During the mid-summer White Nights, crowds gather to watch the bridges being raised; in winter the Neva freezes over, with spectacular ice floes during the spring thaw.

MORNING Tour the **State Hermitage Museum**, an architectural ensemble that includes the magnificent **Winter Palace** and houses a collection of artworks that rivals the Louvre's. Then stroll along the **Moyka** canal to the **Church of the Savior on the Spilled Blood**, marking the spot where Alexander II was assassinated.

AFTERNOON Visit the **Peter and Paul Fortress**, where the Romanovs (now buried in the Peter and Paul Cathedral) imprisoned generations of revolutionaries. Walk on the cruiser **Aurora**, whose guns heralded the October Revolution in 1917.

EVENING Explore the **Haymarket** district (the setting of Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment*), before attending a performance at the **Mariinsky Theater**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

St. Petersburg's international **airport**, Pulkovo, has **buses** and **taxis** to downtown, 11 miles (17 km) away. It's easy to get around by **metro**, **bus**, **marshrutka** (**minibus**), or on foot.

WHERE TO STAY

Randhouse (inexpensive) is a hip B&B chain with good locations. www.randhouse.ru
Casa Leto (moderate) is an elegant mini-hotel near the Hermitage. www.casaletto.com
Grand Hotel Europe (expensive) is true old-style decadence. www.grandhoteleurope.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.visitrussia.org.uk

